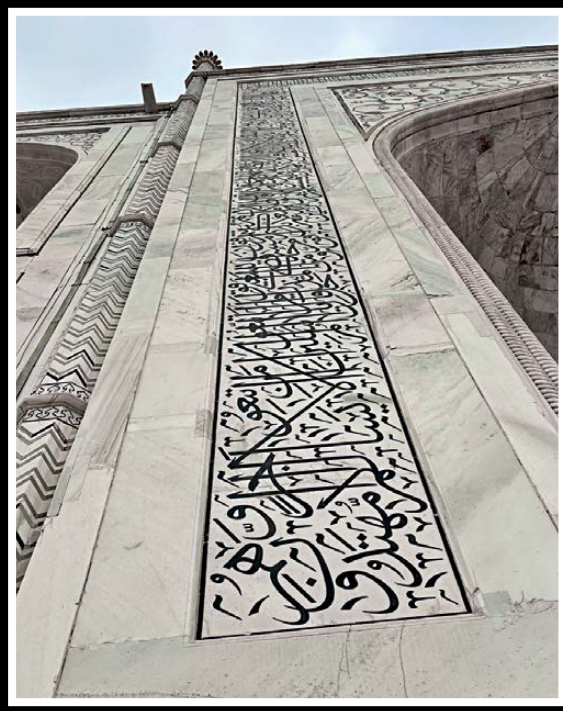
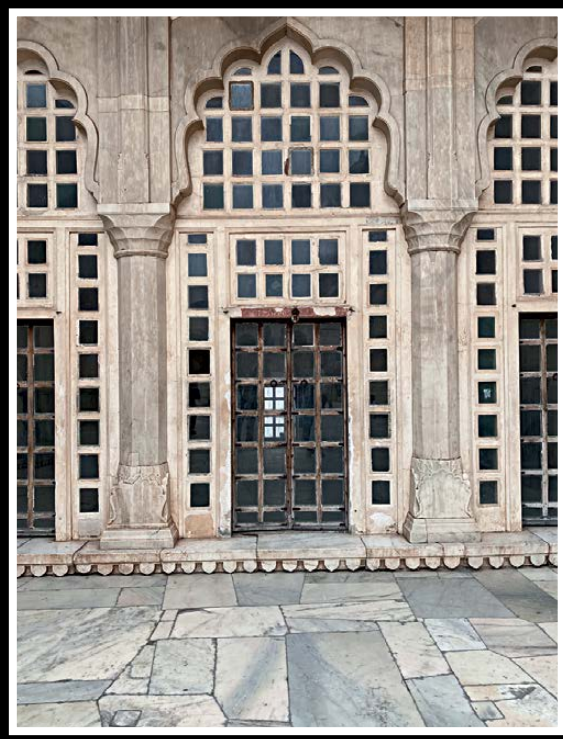




Specialised regional techniques and material origin at the Taj Mahal in Agra define an "appellation of origin" (Top); Sheesh Mahal, Amer reflects climate logic and regional self-similarity through stone, timber, and lime.

lation requires that the entire process of production must be unique to only that specific place, including the source of the raw materials and the human knowledge embedded in the traditions of local communities. Neither is a GI like a trademark in any way in this context. Structured primarily to protect from duplication and fraud, a trademark in a building would be unnecessarily restrictive, especially considering that self-similarity is welcome in our increasingly chaotic urban environments. Trademarks are by their very nature, exclusionary and private; whereas GI mapping is about protecting and promoting not just design, but entire communities—and by extension, the living legacy those communities have inscribed into stone, timber, terracotta, and lime.

The Ultimate Provenance: How GI Tags Turn Ancient Crafts Into Protected Global Luxury

India is at the forefront of this much-needed reversal of local knowledge and resources. A new generation of architects and designers is focussing their practices on making hyperlocal buildings. Like those built centuries before, these buildings carry a distinct impression of where they came from and where they are sited. When we make a building's origins legible—by labelling provenance, process, and place—we can reward artisans, promote lower-carbon, climate-sensitive design, and help the public "read" cities and buildings with the same literacy we bring to products. This is an innovation from the Global South ready to inspire a worldwide shift in how we see and value the very structures we inhabit.

We already label origin on tea, silk, and cheese—and India has proven the power of Geographical Indications (GI) at scale. Europe, meanwhile, demonstrates a cultural appetite for attributing meaning to buildings through Blue Plaques, which mark who lived or created there. My idea bridges these worlds: adapt India's proven, community-centred GI framework to the built environment, moving beyond commemorative plaques toward origin labels for buildings themselves. This is not just about who occupied them, but how they were made, where their materials come from, what climate logic shapes them, and which communities craft them. It is, ultimately, about building legacy into the fabric of the structure itself—so that what endures is not only the building, but the full weight of knowledge, craft, and place that made it possible.